The Ground of Liberty

Paul lays the ground of liberty: his God-given authority as an apostle, and the grace by which believers stand — the very things the Judaizers were undermining.

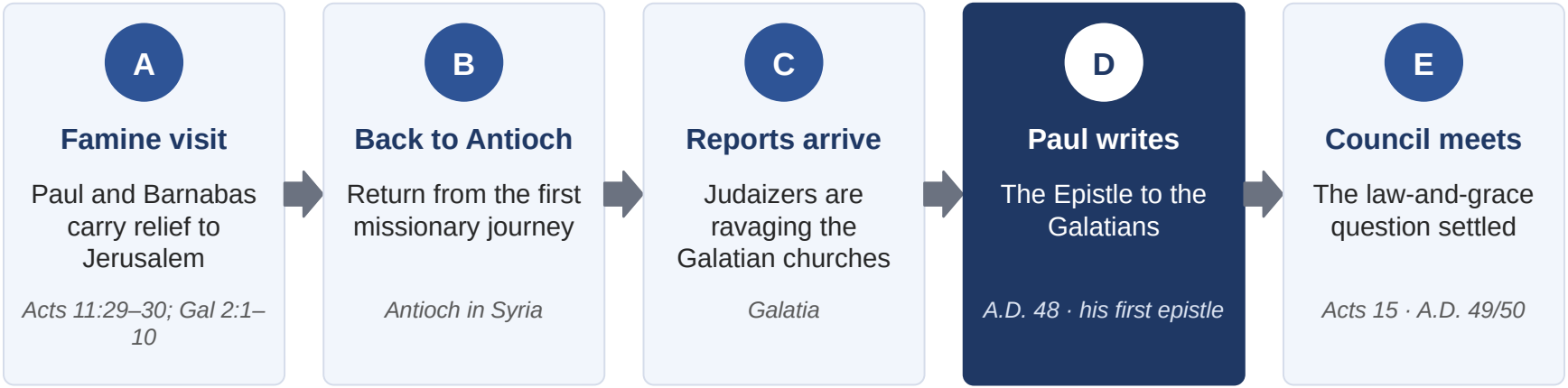
Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 **The Ground of Liberty**	**02** 1:6–10 **The One True Gospel**	**03** 1:11–17 **Paul's Independent Revelation**	**04** 1:18–2:10 **Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches**
05 2:11–21 **Peter Goes Back to School**	**06** 3:1–5 **Under a Spell**	**07** 3:6–14 **Blessing or a Curse**	**08** 3:15–29 **The Superiority of the Promise to the Law**
09 4:1–11 **When I Became a Man**	**10** 4:12–20 **A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove**	**11** 4:21–31 **Paul's Old Testament Story**	**12** 5:1–12 **Taking a Stand in Liberty**
13 5:13–26 **Walk in the Spirit**	**14** 6:1–5 **Brothers and Burdens**	**15** 6:6–10 **Sowing and Reaping**	**16** 6:11–18 **Teaching the Truth**

Where Galatians fits in Acts

Background III–IV · Date and place of writing



Recipients — South Galatia

- The churches of the first journey: Derbe, Lystra, Iconium, Antioch (in Pisidia)
- A group epistle — “to the churches” (1:2)

Written from Antioch in Syria

- Paul's home church and base for several years
- Before the council — so the council's letter is never cited

Why South Galatia?

Background II · The recipients

North Galatia	South Galatia ✓ commentary's view
• Upper region of Asia Minor • Paul did not go there until the second missionary journey • The letter could then be no earlier than about A.D. 53–54	• The churches Paul planted on the first missionary journey • Derbe, Lystra, Iconium, Antioch in Pisidia • The letter comes before the council — A.D. 48

vs

The main reason: no mention of the Jerusalem Council. The council settled this exact issue — Gentiles do not keep the Law for salvation or sanctification. Had it met already, Paul would simply have cited its letter.

Six characteristics of Galatians

Background V · What sets this letter apart

A Contrasts in feelings

Great love for the Galatian believers — and a godly hatred of the Judaizers' teaching

B A group epistle

Like Ephesians, written to a circle of churches, not one congregation

C No thanksgiving

The only Pauline letter with no thanksgiving in the salutation

D Autobiographical

With 2 Corinthians, the letter that tells us most about Paul's own life

E Parallel with Romans

Romans tells what justification by faith is; Galatians tells what it is not

F A unique ending

“Large letters” (6:11) — likely Paul's own large handwriting, due to his eyesight

The Judaizers: their message and their appeal

Background VI · Who Paul is answering

Their message

In the Gospels
Salvation is by the Law — circumcision is necessary for salvation.

In the Epistles
Sanctification is by the Law — keeping the Law is necessary to please God and live a holy life.

Their appeal

1. **The Scriptures on their side**
   Only the OT (plus James, perhaps Matthew) existed — “it says here you must be circumcised”
2. **Natural sympathy, Jew to Jew**
   “We're both Jews here — don't you believe the law?”
3. **Man's religiosity**
   People want something to do: rules, rituals, works
4. **The “mother church”**
   They came from Jerusalem; Paul came from Gentile Antioch

Reading rule from the commentary: remember where we are in Paul's argument, and let that guide how you read any single verse.

“Not from men nor through man”

Galatians 1:1 · Exposition 1 — The Writer

Paul, an apostle
ἀπόστολος apostolos · G652

- “One who is sent”
- Not in dispute: Paul was sent
- In dispute: sent by whom?
- Answering it is the letter's direct purpose

Not from / through men

No group of men
- Not the apostles in Jerusalem
- Not the leaders in Antioch

No single man
- Not Ananias in Damascus
- Not Barnabas, who brought him to Antioch

But through

- Jesus Christ
- and God the Father who raised Him from the dead
- Paul is a spokesman for God

When they couldn't argue with Paul's doctrine, they attacked his person. Verse 1 answers them before the letter begins.

The ground of liberty, verse by verse

Galatians 1:1–5 · Exposition outline points 1–6

v.1	1 · The Writer — “Paul, an apostle”	**ἀπόστολος** sent — but by God, not men
v.2	2 · The Readers — “to the churches of Galatia” (plural)	Derbe, Lystra, Iconium, Antioch
v.3a	3 · The Greeting — “Grace to you and peace”	**χάρις · εἰρήνη** Greek greeting · Jewish greeting
v.3b	4 · The Source — “from God the Father and our Lord Jesus Christ”	the Father is our Father too
v.4a	5 · The Basis — “who gave Himself for our sins”	**δούς · ἑαυτόν** voluntary · total
v.4b	6 · The Purpose — “that He might deliver us from this present evil age”	**ἐξέληται** rescue — now and when He returns
v.5	Doxology — “to whom be glory forever and ever. Amen”	**δόξα** the Father's glory (cf. Phil 2:11)

Grace and peace — a greeting with a point

Galatians 1:3 · Exposition 3 — The Greeting

Grace — the Greek greeting

χάρις charis · G5485 · Nom. Fem. Sg.

- Here, not grace for salvation
- God's unmerited favor sufficient to sustain the believer's daily life
- The very truth the Judaizers undermined by adding law-keeping

Peace — the Jewish greeting

εἰρήνη · שָׁלוֹם eirēnē · G1515 · LXX: shalom

- Positive wholeness and wellness
- Enjoyed when right with God, positionally and experientially
- Only a believer living under grace can extend it

Our goal: hold fast to grace so we may serve God acceptably. You cannot give a greeting of grace apart from living under it.

“Who gave Himself … that He might deliver us”

Galatians 1:4–5 · Exposition 5–6 — Basis and purpose

He gave
δούς Aor. Act. Ptc.

- Active voice
- A voluntary death — not a tragedy that overtook Him
- “No one takes My life from Me”

Himself
ἑαυτόν Acc. Masc. Sg. (reflexive)

- Personal and total surrender
- His whole person, not merely His body
- Ground of complete forgiveness

Might deliver
ἐξέληται Aor. Mid. Subj.

- To pluck out, rescue
- Future: when He returns
- Present: from this evil age now (John 17:15–17)

Salvation is not just a ticket to heaven — but it is that. Verse 5: “to whom be glory forever and ever. Amen.”

Discuss and apply

Galatians 1:1–5 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why does Paul spend so much of verse 1 defending his apostleship before he even gets to his main subject?

2. How does Paul's use of “grace” in verse 3 differ from how the word is often used today?

Apply

Resting in a Settled Identity

Write down one identity truth Scripture gives you and read it aloud each morning this week.

Living Under Grace, Not Under Law

Name one “rule” you've kept to feel acceptable to God, and replace it with a specific act of grateful obedience.

In one line: Paul's authority came from God — and the grace that saves us is the grace that sustains us.